

BAIS: International Relations

Conclusion: Global Politics and the Anthropocene

Dr. Steven Denney

BA International Studies
Leiden University · The Hague

May 18, 2026

Take the Survey Now

Five minutes – today's content + course feedback



- Scan the QR code, or type the link below.
- https://leidenuniv.eu.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_9zaeaAb5G9AN8ZE
- Anonymous. Nothing is linked to your name or student ID.
- Two parts. A few questions on today's lecture, then feedback on the course.
- I read every response. Thanks in advance.

Today at a Glance

Final session – overview and what to focus on

Topic: whether the IR toolkit you spent the semester learning is equipped for the planetary problems we now face – and how to picture the futures that will follow.

- **Two required readings:** the article on whether IR is going extinct, and the chapter on images of global futures.
- **In-class survey** at the top of class – short, anonymous, also collects informal course feedback.
- **This is the final lecture.** Second half is a course review and close.
- **Focus on:** the Anthropocene as a problem for IR (Section A) and the four future challenges (Section B). These are exam material.

Exam Notes

What to know about the final

- **Date:** Wednesday, 27 May 2026. Resit: 30 June 2026. Both delivered via **ANS**.
- **Format:** 20 multiple-choice (50%) + 6 short-answer questions (50%), three from each instructor. **You answer four short answers: two from each set.**
- **Wk 12 focus:** the article's argument about extinction and IR (Section A); the four future challenges (Section B).
- **Study guide:** on Brightspace – format details, candidate topics, glossary of key terms.

Roadmap

Five stops in the last lecture

1. Short in-class survey – engages today's content and collects course feedback
2. The Anthropocene as a problem for IR – the article's provocation
3. Images of global futures – the chapter's four challenges
4. **Break**
5. Course in review and close

Full references are in the supplementary reading guide on Brightspace.

The Anthropocene as a Problem for IR

The Anthropocene as a Problem for IR

Where this section is going

- The Anthropocene names a planetary era shaped by human activity.
- It puts pressure on the categories IR has used for a century.
- Today's question. Is the discipline equipped for it?

Where this lecture sits in the arc

Twelve weeks of toolkit. Sovereignty, anarchy, balance of power, regimes, identity. This is the test case that asks whether that toolkit is still the right one.

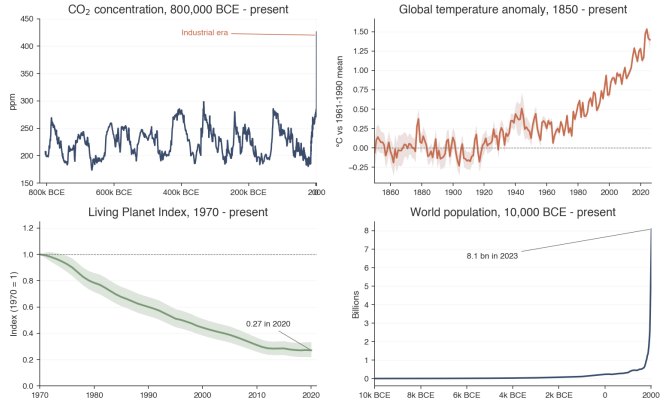
Is IR Going Extinct?

The article's central claim

- Extinction is now a stake in IR.
- A mass extinction event may already be under way.
- IR claims to be a “theory of survival,” yet has no framework for this.
- The discipline keeps extinction in the footnotes.
- Hence the title's pun. Is IR itself going extinct?

Fingerprints of the Anthropocene

Four planetary-scale series in one view



Source: *Our World in Data* – CO₂, temperature anomaly, Living Planet Index, world population.

A State-Centric Ontology, a Planetary Problem

The structural mismatch

- IR's basic unit is the state, bounded and territorial.
- Planetary processes do not respect borders or treaties.
- Climate, biodiversity, oceans operate on geological timescales.
- Sovereignty was built for a different scale of problem.
- The mismatch is structural.

Beyond Management: the Ontological Gap

Why better data is not enough

- Standard response. Better treaties, better data, better targets.
- This treats extinction as a problem of biopolitical management.
- The gap is ontological.
- The field cannot yet think the loss of life forms as such.
- Counting species and grasping what is lost are different tasks.

Anthropocentrism as the Blind Spot

The taboo against thinking extinction

- IR centers a particular image of “humanity” as the only subject.
- Nonhumans and inhuman forces are treated as backdrop.
- Survival becomes “our” survival, on “our” terms.
- That premise rules questions about extinction out of bounds.
- The taboo is structural.

Posthumanist and Planetary Thinking

What the article proposes instead

- Decentering the human as the only subject of ethics.
- Taking nonhuman and inhuman forces seriously as actors.
- Extending IR's temporal horizon before and after humans.
- "Cosmopolitics." Politics rooted in a shared planet.
- An ethics of gratitude and welcome that goes beyond survival.

Anthropocene Glossary

Working terms from this section

Term	Working definition
Anthropocene	A proposed geological epoch in which human activity is the dominant force shaping earth systems. In IR, the term flags planetary processes that exceed the scale of state action.
Environmental security	Reframing security to include ecological threats – climate change, biodiversity loss, resource scarcity – alongside or above military ones.
Planetary boundaries	A framework that names earth-system processes with safe operating limits (climate, biodiversity, freshwater, biogeochemical, land-use, ocean acidification, aerosols, ozone, novel entities). Several are already exceeded.
Ontology vs. management	The distinction between asking <i>what</i> extinction is (ontology) and asking <i>how</i> to govern it (management). The article argues IR is stuck in the second register.
Post-humanism	A family of approaches that decenters the human as the sole subject of ethics and politics. It takes nonhuman and inhuman forces as actors in their own right.

Images of Global Futures

Images of Global Futures

How futures do political work

- How we picture the future shapes what we do now.
- Futures are political claims.
- The chapter walks through four future challenges in turn.

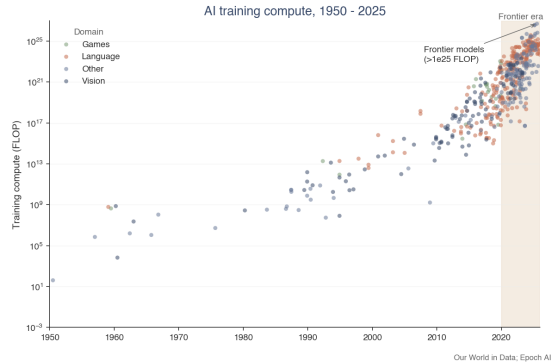
The four challenges

Technology and AI. The space frontier. Ecology and planetary boundaries. Migration.

Technology and Artificial Intelligence

Capability moves faster than governance

- Rapid capability gains, slow governance response.
- Dual-use problems. The same tool secures and surveils.
- Autonomy in weapons, decisions, infrastructure.
- Who writes the rules, and for whom?
- Risk distributed unevenly across regions and classes.



Source: Our World in Data; Epoch AI. Y-axis log-scaled.

The Space Frontier

Old treaties, new industries

- Great power competition extended beyond Earth.
- Dual-use satellites, anti-satellite weapons, lunar resources.
- A treaty regime from the 1960s for a very different industry.
- Private actors now rival states in launch and orbit.
- A governance vacuum at altitude and on the ground.

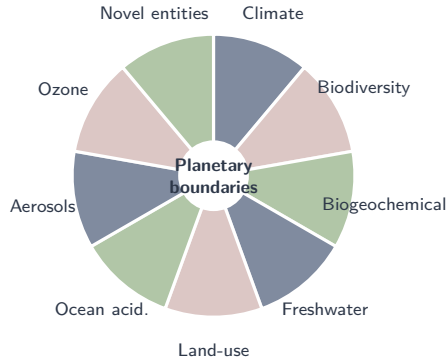
Ecology and Planetary Boundaries

Biodiversity loss as a security problem

- Biodiversity loss as a security problem.
- Climate change as a threat multiplier across regions.
- Tipping points. Nonlinear, hard to reverse, easy to ignore.
- “Resilience” can become a way of asking the vulnerable to absorb the cost.
- Equity shapes access to adaptation.

The Nine Planetary Boundaries

The nine categories the literature tracks



- The framework asks which earth-system processes have a safe operating space, and which have been pushed past it.
- Several boundaries are already in the high-risk zone – climate, biodiversity, biogeochemical flows.
- For IR, the question is whose policies push the boundaries and who pays when they break.

Stylized – not to scale.

Migration as a Future Challenge

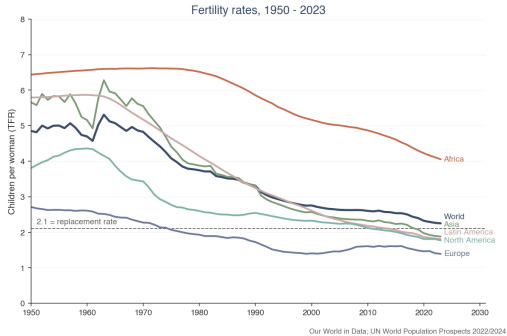
The future mobilized in the present

- Climate-driven displacement projected at unprecedented scale.
- Refugee law was written for a different kind of crisis.
- Internal displacement often exceeds cross-border movement.
- Border politics increasingly shaped by anticipated flows.
- Who counts as a refugee remains a deeply political question.

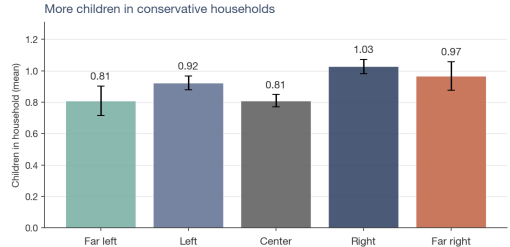
Fertility Might Be the Key Variable

Almost everything else is downstream of it

- Political composition drifts. Progressive fertility has fallen faster than conservative.



ISSP 2023 -- ages 30-50, 33 countries pooled



ISSP 2023, ages 30-50, pooled across 33 countries.

Futures That Enable or Disable Change

The political work futures do

- Futures are tools. They can open or close political space.
- “Inevitable” futures often serve the interests of the present.
- Alternative futures are a resource for politics.
- The course ends here, but the questions stay with you.

Break

See you in 10 minutes.

Course in Review

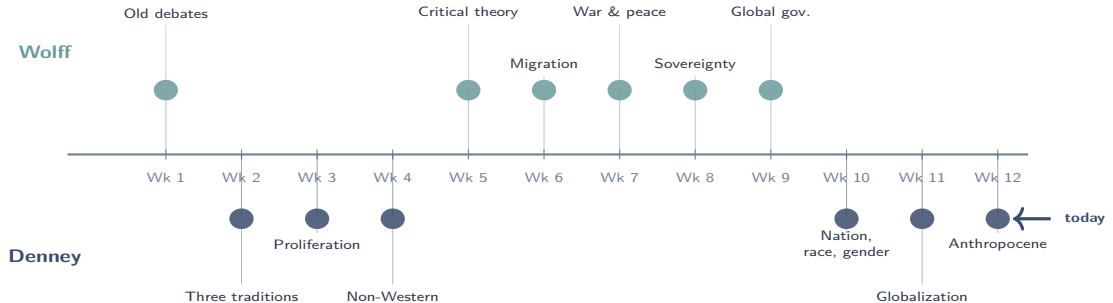
Where We've Been

One sentence to carry into the exam

- Twelve weeks, two instructors, one toolkit.
- A quick recap of the through-line, then on to the exam.
- The goal is to see the connections between weeks.

The Course Arc

Twelve weeks, two instructors



Six weeks each, alternated by section. The three through-lines below run across the arc.

Constructivism and Global IR

Sister critiques of the mainstream

- Constructivism puts ideas, identity, and norms at the center of state behavior.
- Global IR points out that the discipline's own concepts carry a Western location.
- Sister critiques of mainstream theory, from inside and outside.
- Both ask who gets to define what counts as theory.
- Both refuse the realist claim that material power explains everything.

Nationalism and Populism

Analytically separable, empirically fused

- Nationalism as structure – a long-running form of political community.
- Populism as repertoire – a style of mobilization, left or right.
- Analytically separable, empirically often fused.
- The 2010s and 2020s show why. Backlash mobilizes the nation.
- A favorite short-answer trap is collapsing the two.

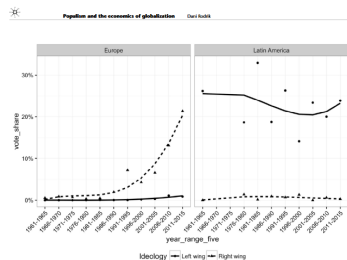


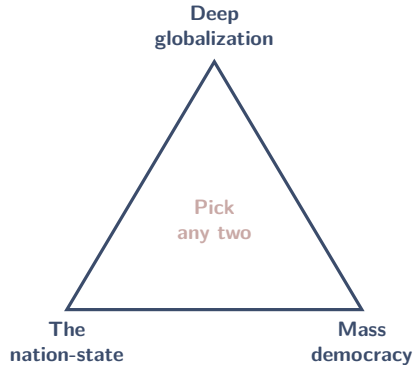
Figure 4 Contrasting patterns of populism in Europe and Latin America. Notes: See Appendix for sources and methods.

Source: from Week 11 – right populism in Europe vs left populism in Latin America.

The Globalization Trilemma

One idea, three lectures

- Three goals – deep globalization, the nation-state, mass democracy. Pick two.
- Previewed in Week 8 on world orders.
- Carried the load of Week 11 on globalization and populism.
- Reappears in Week 12 when the planet enters the picture.
- One idea linking economic, political, and ecological strain.



What Ties It All Together

The meta-lesson

- IR is a contested toolkit, and every tool answers a different question.
- The post-1989 settlement is fraying along several seams at once.
- The work of this course was to give you the language for those seams.

Thank you for a good semester.

Good luck on 27 May.

Appendix: References

Appendix: References

Scholars whose work informed today's lecture and the course

- Acharya, A. (2014). International relations theory and the “rise of Asia.” In Pekkanen et al. (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of the International Relations of Asia*. Oxford UP.
- Coward, M., Paterson, M., Devetak, R., Moulin, C., Shah, N., Zehfuss, M., & Zevnik, A. (2024). On the horizon: The futures of IR. *Review of International Studies*, 50(3), 415–424.
- Grove, J. (2018). The geopolitics of extinction: From the Anthropocene to the Eurocene. In D. R. McCarthy (ed.), *Technology and World Politics*. Routledge.
- Heywood, A., & Whitham, B. (2023). *Global Politics* (3rd ed.). Bloomsbury Academic.
- Lacy, M. (2024). The future of control / the control of the future: Global (dis)order and the weaponisation of everywhere in 2074. *Review of International Studies*, 50(3), 560–578.
- Mearsheimer, J. J. (2019). Bound to fail: The rise and fall of the liberal international order. *International Security*, 43(4), 7–50.
- Mishra, P. (2017). *Age of Anger: A History of the Present*. Allen Lane.
- Mitchell, A. (2017). Is IR going extinct? *European Journal of International Relations*, 23(1), 3–25.
- Mitchell, A., & Chaudhury, A. (2020). Worlding beyond “the” “end” of “the world”: White apocalyptic visions and BIPOC futurisms. *International Relations*, 34(3), 309–332.
- Rodrik, D. (2018). Populism and the economics of globalization. *Journal of International Business Policy*, 1(1), 12–33.
- Sagan, S. D. (1996). Why do states build nuclear weapons? *International Security*, 21(3), 54–86.
- Wendt, A. (1992). Anarchy is what states make of it. *International Organization*, 46(2), 391–425.